With the help of Khan Kabir, Dost Mohammad adopted the disguise of a Sufi fakir, just as Shah Shuja had done when escaping from Ranjit Singh in Lahore thirty years earlier. Initially the Amir took the wrong route, and in his panic killed the horse he had been given, riding it to its death over barren mountains. Just as he was wandering lost and alone in the high-altitude desert and about to give up hope, he was picked up by a camel caravan heading for Balkh. 'The Amir was provided with a camel bearing baskets on both sides,' wrote Mohan Lal, who later became Dost Mohammad's first biographer,

> and in one of these baskets, the Amir placed himself under the pretence of indisposition. In Chiraghchi [where he had been surrounded and captured the previous year] the servants of the Bukhara government, being previously informed of the escape of the Amir from the city, suspected his being in the caravan. They examined every camel basket, but could not discover him, since he had cunningly coloured his silver beard with ink, which he found by himself for the occasion, and the informer was punished by the officers for bringing them into ridicule with a false report.[87]

For the next few weeks, the Amir kept with the caravan but, as he had no money, lived only on what he could beg. The Afghan oral tradition is full of stories of the Amir's trials and sufferings on his travels, some of which Fayz Mohammad gathered into his history. 'At Shahr-i Sabz, the Amir dismounted before a ramshackle hostel for dervishes,' he recorded. Here a few men were sitting around drinking tea with milk.

> The Amir was very hungry and with an eye to perhaps getting some tea from them, he sat down near the door of the hostel. But those inconsiderate people, who call themselves qalandars [holy fools] but certainly did not have the character of holy men, said not a word to him, and offered him nothing. With stomach still empty, he then went into the city and asked for a certain merchant named Mullah Kabir who was from Kabul and had a family there in Shahr-i Sabz . . . When he saw the Amir, Mullah Kabir kissed his hand and escorted him to his house. As they entered the house, the mullah was overcome with compassion at seeing the Amir dressed as a dervish and wept. He put himself at the Amir's disposal and did everything it was in his power to do.

After he had rested, the Amir despatched Mullah Kabir to the Governor of Shahr-i Sabz to tell him of his arrival.

> As soon as he heard the news, the governor came to Mullah Kabir's house and showed the Amir the highest regard, moving him into the royal guesthouse. After performing the duties of host, he spoke about the ignominious behaviour of the Amir of Bukhara and offered to send an army